

So you're thinking about agriculture

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI.

Livestock husbandry: 3.4 out of 10. Field farming: 4.0.

Precision agriculture technology: 6.2. Agricultural data and supply planning: 7.0.

The tech-forward version of this career is more exposed than the hands-on one. Same pattern as biology, and it surprises everyone.

But agriculture also has something no other career in our index has: **it already ran this whole experiment, seventy-five years ago.**

The 60-second version

- Hands-on production work is well protected. Livestock and field work score in the low 3s and 4s.
 - The "modern" agtech and data roles score worse than driving a tractor.
 - **Agriculture already lost three-quarters of its workforce while tripling output.** That's the real lesson.
 - And the honest issue isn't AI at all: USDA forecasts the median farm household will **lose money farming in 2026.**
 - Which makes one distinction matter more than anything: **farming vs working in agriculture.**
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What agriculture already proved

This is the most useful thing in this document, and it applies to every career you might consider.

From USDA's own data:

- Self-employed and family farmworkers fell from **7.6 million in 1950 to 2.06 million by 2000** — down 73%
- Hired farmworkers fell from 2.33 million to 1.13 million — down 51%
- And over the same era, **total farm output nearly tripled**

Three-quarters of the workforce gone. Output tripled.

That's a more complete displacement than anything currently happening in law, design or software. It took decades, it happened through machinery rather than software, and almost nobody outside farming noticed.

Three things it teaches:

Automation removed the labour, not the work. Somebody still farms. There are just far fewer of them, at much bigger scale, with much more capital.

The survivors got bigger, not safer. 6% of US farms — the ones selling over \$1 million — produce more than three-quarters of everything. Meanwhile 74% of farms produce 2% of output.

And it was invisible from outside, because it happened gradually and food kept arriving.

The inversion

Precision agriculture — GPS guidance, yield mapping, drone imagery, variable-rate application, decision platforms — is the modern, technical, well-regarded end of farming.

And it scores **6.2** against field farming's **4.0**.

Why? Ask what the work actually is.

Precision ag takes structured data — soil samples, yield maps, weather, imagery — and produces recommendations. Structured inputs, analytical outputs, no physical presence, no licensed accountability. That's the exposed profile in every field we scored.

Field work needs you there. Livestock don't cooperate. Weather changes the plan. Equipment breaks at 6am in a field. Soil isn't what the map said.

And the recommendations precision ag produces — seeding rate, nitrogen timing, spray decisions — are exactly the kind of optimisation problem that automates well. The person reading the data is more replaceable than the person deciding, at 5am in the rain, whether the field will travel.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Livestock husbandry & animal management	3.4
Agricultural equipment technology & repair	3.8
Field farming & crop production	4.0
Farm management	4.6
Agronomy & crop advisory	5.4
Precision agriculture technology	6.2
Agricultural data & supply planning	7.0

Hands and animals at the top. Screens and data at the bottom.

Now the part that actually decides this

USDA's 2026 forecast:

Median farm income earned by farm households: -\$1,161. Negative.

Median off-farm income: \$92,815.

Read that again. The median American farm household loses *money farming* and earns nearly \$93,000 doing something else. USDA says outright that many farm households primarily rely on off-farm income.

And from the Census of Agriculture: only 43% of US farms had positive net cash farm income.

Three things follow:

Small-scale farm ownership often isn't a job — it's a business that frequently doesn't pay. Plenty of people choose it knowingly, funded by other income. But you should know that at seventeen, not at thirty.

Scale decides everything. 6% of farms produce 75%+ of output. Agriculture rewards capital more than almost any sector.

And it's policy-dependent — \$44.3 billion in direct government payments in 2026.

Which is why this distinction matters most

"Farming" and "working in agriculture" are different careers.

The second one pays a wage, and it's where most agricultural employment actually is:

- **Equipment technology** — scores 3.8, chronically short of people
- **Agronomy** (field-based, not platform-based)
- **Animal health and livestock management**
- **Food safety and quality assurance**
- **Agribusiness, input supply, commodity work**

And agricultural wage employment has been *rising* — from 1.13 million in 2013 to 1.17 million in 2023.

The one I'd point you at

Agricultural equipment technology.

Modern machinery is heavily electronic — GPS guidance, variable-rate systems, telematics, and increasingly electrified drivetrains. You need to diagnose mechanical, hydraulic *and* electronic faults together.

It's physical, diagnostic, unpredictable work — which is exactly the protected profile — and **technicians who can do all three are short everywhere.**

Scores **3.8**. Almost nobody your age is aiming at it.

What we won't soften

The economics above. They're the main thing.

Capital requirements are brutal. Land and machinery make entry into ownership nearly impossible without inheritance or serious backing. That's why the average producer age has been high for decades.

It's **physically dangerous** — agriculture has among the highest occupational fatality rates of any sector.

And **weather and market risk are effectively uninsurable**. A bad year is genuinely a bad year.

One honest thing about the score

We rate field farming 4.0, and we should tell you the strongest argument against that.

Agriculture has automated physical work continuously for a century. Autonomous tractors, robotic milking and automated harvesting are in commercial deployment *now* — not in labs. This is the sector where "the physical work is safe" has been tested longest, and held least well.

We hold the score because what's left is disproportionately the *unstructured* part — the field that doesn't match the map, the animal that's unwell, the machine that broke somewhere inconvenient.

But if you're seventeen and planning forty years, weight that history heavily.

Does this actually sound like you?

It suits people who:

- **Genuinely want to be outdoors**, in all conditions, permanently
- Are **practically and mechanically capable** — that's most of modern farm work
- Can handle **uncertainty they don't control** — weather, disease, prices
- Are **comfortable with animals**, if that's the direction
- **Think in seasons** rather than weeks

Harder if you need predictable income, want defined hours (livestock and harvest don't negotiate), or are drawn to the *idea* of farming without having done it in February.

Two things worth doing

Work a full season — including winter. Agriculture is romanticised more than almost any career we've looked at, and a February morning answers the question faster than anything else.

Then talk to two people: someone farming at scale, and someone working in agriculture — a technician, an agronomist, a food safety manager. Compare what they earn and what their week looks like. That contrast is basically this whole document.

One last thing

Working outdoors, with animals or land, where results are visible and seasonal — very few careers offer that at all, and it's a real reason to want this.

The economics are hard and the history is instructive. Neither of those is the same as saying don't.

Just be clear about which version you're choosing, and be honest about land and capital early rather than late.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **USDA Farm Sector Income Forecast** — read this one first. It's where the median farm household figures come from, and it's the government's own data.
 - **Census of Agriculture** — the structural picture: farm sizes, who produces what, producer demographics.
 - **USDA Farm Labor** — the seventy-five-year employment history. Worth seeing the actual numbers.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the economics in detail, what to ask a programme, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.